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**Perspectives on value creation in Canadian SME/Non-Profit CSR
partnerships 2020: a maturity framework**

David Marshall

Dissertation Proposal

I, David Marshall, declare that I am the sole author of this assignment and the work is a result of my own investigations, except where otherwise stated. I confirm that I have read the University regulations on plagiarism.

All references have been duly cited.

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1. Introduction

1.1 Problem definition and purpose

Over the last ten years, the number of people giving to non-profit organisations (NPOs) in Canada has declined by 20%. The most significant drop has been with people under 55, 30% of whom cite a declining trust in NPOs with respect to the efficiency and effectiveness of how charitable gifts are used. Going against this trend, however, is an increased public awareness of global issues, and a corresponding increase in giving to NPOs that work in these areas (CanadaHelps 2020; Lasby and Barr 2018).

At the same time, this increased awareness in social justice issues, sustainability goals and globalisation has intensified the demands on businesses to not just minimize the harm they do, but also to proactively engage in positive societal change (Green et al. 2019; Kingo and Lacy 2019; Deloitte 2020).

These trends, driven by global mass communication, are likely to continue. As pressure for change builds, new opportunities will emerge for businesses and NPOs engaged in international issues to work together. Through collaboration, NPOs will build their capacity and regain stakeholder trust, while businesses will learn how to adopt global purpose into their cultures. As they collaborate and learn how to navigate rapid societal shifts together, business and NPO leaders will need to listen deeply and build relationships that move beyond philanthropy and the transactional exchanges of the past (Nwagbara and Reid 2013a; 2013b; Davies 2018; Remund and McKeever 2018; C&E 2019; Senge, Hamilton and Kania 2019; Tesserars 2019; Zheng 2020).

This study will research the concept of collaborative value creation (CVC) (Austin and Seitanidi 2012a, 2012b; 2014; 2016) with a focus on why leaders of Canadian small or medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) form CSR partnerships with NPOs and how they perceive CVC in order to understand how to develop a maturity framework that will assist an NPO in establishing such collaborations.

1.2 Research Objectives

1. To critically evaluate literature on CVC between businesses and NPOs.
2. Evaluate, based on qualitative data gained in interviews, how SME/NPO collaborations in Canada are optimised to create real and measurable value to both parties.
3. Develop a maturity framework in order to guide CVC between a Canadian NPO engaged in social justice issues in the global south and Canadian SMEs.

The research objectives, will be guided by the following:

1.3 Research Question

“How can a Canadian NPO engaged in social justice issues in the global south and a Canadian SME effectively collaborate to create measurable shared value?”

2. Literature Review

2.1 The evolution of CSR and its impact on Canadian SMEs.

Bowen (1953) may have been the first to coin the term CSR, but the concept dates back many centuries. Since the 1970s significant study on the nature and exercise of CSR and how to mitigate corporate social irresponsibility (CSI) has been undertaken and this continues to evolve with societal shifts (Carroll 2008; 2015) (Appendix 1&2). This constant evolution makes CSR difficult to define, indeed Pedersen (2009,2015) argues it is impossible to reach a common understanding of CSR given its vagueness, ambiguity, and lack of clarity, though he goes on to say that van Marrewijk (2003) captures the central components of CSR as “company activities – voluntary by definition – demonstrating the inclusion of social and environmental concerns in business operations and in interactions with stakeholders”.

In Canada, the writer would argue that CSR is no longer voluntary, indeed the Business Development Bank Canada (2020) define it as “a company’s commitment to manage the social, environmental and economic effects of its operations responsibly and in line with public expectations”. But how do we understand ever-changing public expectations in the face of

increasing cynicism around the motives for CSR as either a publicity stunt to increase profits or hide CSI. No longer the prerogative of big industry, CSR is now an essential element of all business regardless of size, sector or industry. As the call for social justice, environmental stewardship and sustainability grows louder, businesses need to assess, adjust to, and manage CSR perception. Being philanthropic and doing good is not enough, it is now about doing right and with less resources than large corporates, the complexities and expectations of CSR combined with increased competition and scarce resources, can become overwhelming for SMEs who generate over 50% of Canadas GDP. Those in search of a wider customer base will need to more clearly articulate their value proposition to their target audience (Industry Canada 2014; Carroll 2015; El Akremi et al. 2018; Government of Canada 2019; Huang, Canada and Innovation 2020).

Traditionally SMEs who engaged in CSR were more likely to build goodwill and support leading to growth, by supporting local community initiatives rather than more global CSR activities such as the environment (Porter and Kramer 2006; Stoian and Gilman 2017). However; the writer would argue that in an increasingly global community; inequality, terrorism, pandemics and global warming are seen as a problem for everyone and as such social justice and environmental stewardship are key messages that resonate with the majority of Canadians. Developing strategies around that are becoming essential to engage all stakeholders.

2.2 Creating Shared Value (CSV) & Integrated Value Creation (IVC)

However, there are those that argue despite the growing demand for CSR that it should not become the core of business. Epstein (2020) believes that Friedman is still right in that the role of business is to make a profit and not engage in social engineering or endless stakeholders demands. Though even he acknowledges that maximising social welfare is now inextricably linked with maximising profit.

Rather than argue the semantics of whether shareholder value, customer creation (Friedman 1970; Drucker 1973) or CSR should be the core of business, this paper takes the pragmatic approach that profit is vital to corporate sustainability and that CSR is an essential aspect of

value creation necessary to win customers and so generate profits. CSR does not need to be the vision and mission of a business, which must always focus primarily on profitability, rather CSR should sit in purpose, which Newell (2014) points out must evolve to benefit society as well as making profits. It will also speak to values and how the business behaves while going about its mission.

Industry Canada (2014) highlights a “social license to operate” as a key benefit of a CSR strategy (Appendix 3) which resonates with Porters (1980, 1996) focus on deliberate choices around competitive differentiation. In a changing world, corporate strategy which, Johnson, Whittington, and Scholes (2011) define as the “long-term direction of an organisation” must now include CSR as an element of competitive advantage and creating shared value (CSV) is an acknowledgement of that interdependency between social and business results (Porter and Kramer 2011; Porter et al. 2012).

Visser (2015, 2018) takes it a step further and argues that value creation has evolved beyond CSV (Appendix 4) he believes that in order for businesses to move from being part of the problem to being part of the solution to global challenges, they will need to think in terms of integrated value creation (IVC) using it as a tool for innovation and transformation.

Navigating such expansive and complex issues though is a challenge for all business, and in particular lower resourced SMEs. The solution, it is suggested is to employ dialogic cross-sector collaborative partnerships (CSCPs) designed to develop mutually enhancing strengths to deliver real economic, social and environmental outcomes and thus achieve corporate legitimacy (Colaneri, Imanaka and Prussia 2018; Elkington 2018; Ellerup Nielsen and Thomsen 2018). (Appendix 5)

2.3 Collaborative Value Creation (CVC): Business/ NPO Partnerships

Crane and Seitanidi (2014); however discuss the challenges of business/NPO CSCPs and propose a general framework to deal with these from the perspective of CVC (Seitanidi 2008; Seitanidi and Crane 2009; Austin and Seitanidi 2012a, 2012b)

They start from the premise that as the point of the collaboration between businesses and NPOs is to “co-create significant economic, social, and environmental value for society, organizations, and individuals” one must therefore start with the desired outcome - i.e. the impact one wants to achieve. The investment required to deliver that impact is then determined, much like a theory of change (TOC) or logic frame model both commonly used by NPOs but rarely in the business world who tend to prefer tools, such as Kaplan and Nortons (1992; 2001a; 2001b) Balanced Score Card (BSC).

Austin and Seitanidis (2016) CVC framework comprises four different components:

Component		
1	Value Creation Spectrum	Defines the sources of value activated by the partnership in terms of resource complementarity, nature, directionality and use and linked interests. It considers how each partners can fill gaps in the others resources along with the attitudes and perceptions held by the partners to distinguish what objectively substantiates the partnership from the way in which the partners “see” or “make sense of” of the value creation processes.
2	Collaboration Stages	Focuses on how the collaboration is developing on a spectrum from philanthropic to transformational depending on key value drivers of change and how system-level innovations are the primary focus of a transformational partnership.
3	Partnership Processes	Is about how the collaboration process evolves to create value and deliver transformation
4	Collaborative Outcomes	Focuses on outcomes of the partnership and how value creation impacts across multiples levels such as individuals, organizations, and society.

Collaborative Value Creation (CVC) Framework. Adapted from Austin and Seitanidi (2016)

The collaborative stages component is viewed as a continuum which recognises the dynamic nature of collaborations (Austin and Seitanidi 2012b).

	<u>Stage I</u>	<u>Stage II</u>	<u>Stage III</u>	<u>Stage IV</u>
NATURE OF RELATIONSHIP	<i>Philanthropic>Transactional>Integrative>Transformational</i>			
• Level of Engagement	<i>Low←-----→High</i>			
• Importance to Mission	<i>Peripheral ←-----→Central</i>			
• Magnitude of Resources	<i>Small←-----→Big</i>			
• Type of resources	<i>Money←-----→Core Competencies</i>			
• Scope of Activities	<i>Narrow←-----→Broad</i>			
• Interaction Level	<i>Infrequent←-----→Intensive</i>			
• Trust	<i>Modest←-----→Deep</i>			
• Internal change	<i>Minimal←-----→Great</i>			
• Managerial Complexity	<i>Simple←-----→Complex</i>			
• Strategic Value	<i>Minor←-----→Major</i>			
• Co-creation of value	<i>Sole-----→Conjoined</i>			
• Synergistic value	<i>Occasional←-----→Predominant</i>			
• Innovation	<i>Seldom←-----→Frequent</i>			
• External system change	<i>Rare←-----→Common</i>			

The Collaboration Continuum (Austin and Seitanidi 2012b)

Ultimately the legitimacy of the CVC is dependent on the ability to measure outcomes and impact in order to verify the ROI/value of the collaboration. This requires evidence-based impact assessments, not anecdotal CSR reports and while this has long being a priority for NPOs, it is a key shift for the business world. Kaplan (2010) acknowledges that the BSC misses the link between output and impact, while other critics go further saying the BSC has not kept up with evolving business models in that it excludes key stakeholders in defining objectives, is increasingly incompatible with organisational culture, no longer offers adequate insight into value creation, limits strategic thinking, and hinders innovation (Austin and Seitanidi 2014; Madsen and Stenheim 2014, Cooper and Ezzamel 2016; Davis 2016; Nielsen, Lund and Thomsen 2017)

While businesses and NPOs may enter a collaborative relationship with similar objectives, NPOs frequently have concerns around power imbalance and potential reputational risk. Shifting how ROI is measured, however, can help balance the NPOs social power with the traditionally more

dominant financial giving power of the business. Additionally, when leadership is committed and open to culture change then high-value partnerships can be developed as ethical values and purpose are re-evaluated, thus increasing the chances of a successful collaboration (Rundall 2000; Wymer and Samu 2003; Selsky and Parker 2005; Baur and Schmitz 2012; Marano and Tashman 2012; van Tulder et al. 2016; Sanzo, Álvarez and Rey 2017; Al-Tabbaa, Leach and Khan 2019; Poret 2019).

3. Research Methodology

3.1 Research philosophy and data collection

As illustrated in appendix 6, previous researchers performing similar studies to this have generally chosen qualitative methods. Likewise, this study takes an inductive approach to theory development based on an interpretive philosophy to analyse primary data collected from semi-structured exploratory interviews in a cross-sectional study. This involves symbolic interactionism which is rooted in the discipline of phenomenology and as such interviews will be approached as co-constructive dialogues where knowledge is gathered on the understanding that it will be dependent on context, and meaning is constructed or negotiated as part of the interaction between the researcher and research participants. The researcher must be reflexive in the research process, striving to be sensitive to his own prejudices and subjectivity and how that might influence the process and resultant findings. Ten CEO's of Canadian SMEs will be selected via a purposive, non-random, sampling technique based on their decision making power with respect to CSR strategies. Interviews will commence with basic fact gathering questions to put the interviewee at ease, followed by in-depth conversation with the goal of obtaining rich, detailed answers and thus the interview design may evolve during data collection (Wisker 2008; Glesne 2011; Bryman and Bell 2015; Kvale and Brinkmann 2015; Robson and McCartan 2016; Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill 2016; O'Leary 2017; Denzin and Lincoln 2018; Smith 2018).

Secondary data will be collected through a critical evaluation of literature on CVC between businesses and NPOs

3.2 Analysis

Each interview will be recorded and transcribed verbatim in order to allow for careful and detailed review. Additionally, written notes will be made with respect to reactions such as facial expression and body language as the interview proceeds. The next step will involve thematic content analysis where the data is organised into meaningful themes and categories that emerge from the data developed by the writer for further analysis and interpretation. Emerging patterns will be tested against the secondary data which will direct further analysis and provide triangulation in order to develop and test theories. It is also proposed to undertake limited participant validation (Coffey and Atkinson 1996; Burnard et al. 2008; Marshall and Rossman 2011).

3.3 Ethical Considerations

Research will be conducted in accordance with the York St John University (2020) research ethics policy and BERA (2018) ethical guidelines. A participant consent form will clearly identify the purpose of the research and assure privacy and confidentiality (Oppenheim 1992; Fisher and Buglear 2010).

3.3 Expected Outcomes

This could be of significance to both SME and NPO practitioners in developing effective CSR partnerships for the benefit of both parties.

4. Limitations

Cross sectional research based on interpreting perceptions of societal shifts at a time of extraordinary upheaval could be limited by the small purposively selected sample size which while chosen to produce rich dialogue, could affect the research process and lead to incorrect conclusions. This could be further amplified by the researcher's position on such matters and inaccurate inductive qualitative data analysis which may result due to researcher experience, time restraint and bias.

Acknowledgment and explicit recognition of the limitations in advance combined with a thorough literature review regarding best practice in dealing with them will be key to mitigating their impact (Berger 2013; Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill 2016).

5. Timeline

David Marshall, Student #: 1291211316, Timeline				Jun-20			Jul-20			Aug-20					Sep-20				Oct-20				Nov-20				Dec-20				### ##			
				15	22	29	6	13	20	27	3	10	17	24	31	7	14	21	28	5	12	19	26	2	9	16	23	30	7	14	21	28	4	11
TASK	START	END		1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26	27	28	29	30	31
Dissertation Proposal			D																															
Finalising research question and objectives	15/6/20	19/7/20	34																															
Meeting with supervisor	3/7/20	3/7/20																																
First draft to dissertation supervisor	3/7/20	19/7/20																																
Second draft to dissertation supervisor	20/7/20	28/7/20																																
Completing the research proposal	29/7/20	7/8/20	9																															
Submit the research proposal and research ethics form	7/8/20	7/8/20																																
Dissertation																																		
Organise semi-structured interviews zoom meetings	8/8/20	30/8/20	22																															
Determine interview questions and structure	8/8/20	30/8/20	22																															
Literature review	8/8/20	4/10/20	57																															
Compile and send out participator consent form	30/8/20	30/8/20	0																															
Conduct pilot interview and tweak questions	31/8/20	2/9/20	2																															
Conduct and record the interviews	2/9/20	18/9/20	16																															
Transcribe the interviews and data analysis	11/9/20	11/10/20	30																															
Submit draft literature review	4/10/20	4/10/20																																
Write up research methodology, results and findings	4/10/20	25/10/20	21																															
Write up discussion, conclusions, recommendation and Abstract	25/10/20	15/11/20	21																															
Submit first full draft	15/11/20	15/11/20																																
Corrections and adjustments	22/11/20	13/12/20	21																															
Submit second full draft	13/12/20	13/12/20																																
Corrections and adjustments	20/12/20	3/1/21	14																															
Final contemplations	3/1/21	10/1/21	7																															
Submit dissertation	10/1/21	10/1/21																																

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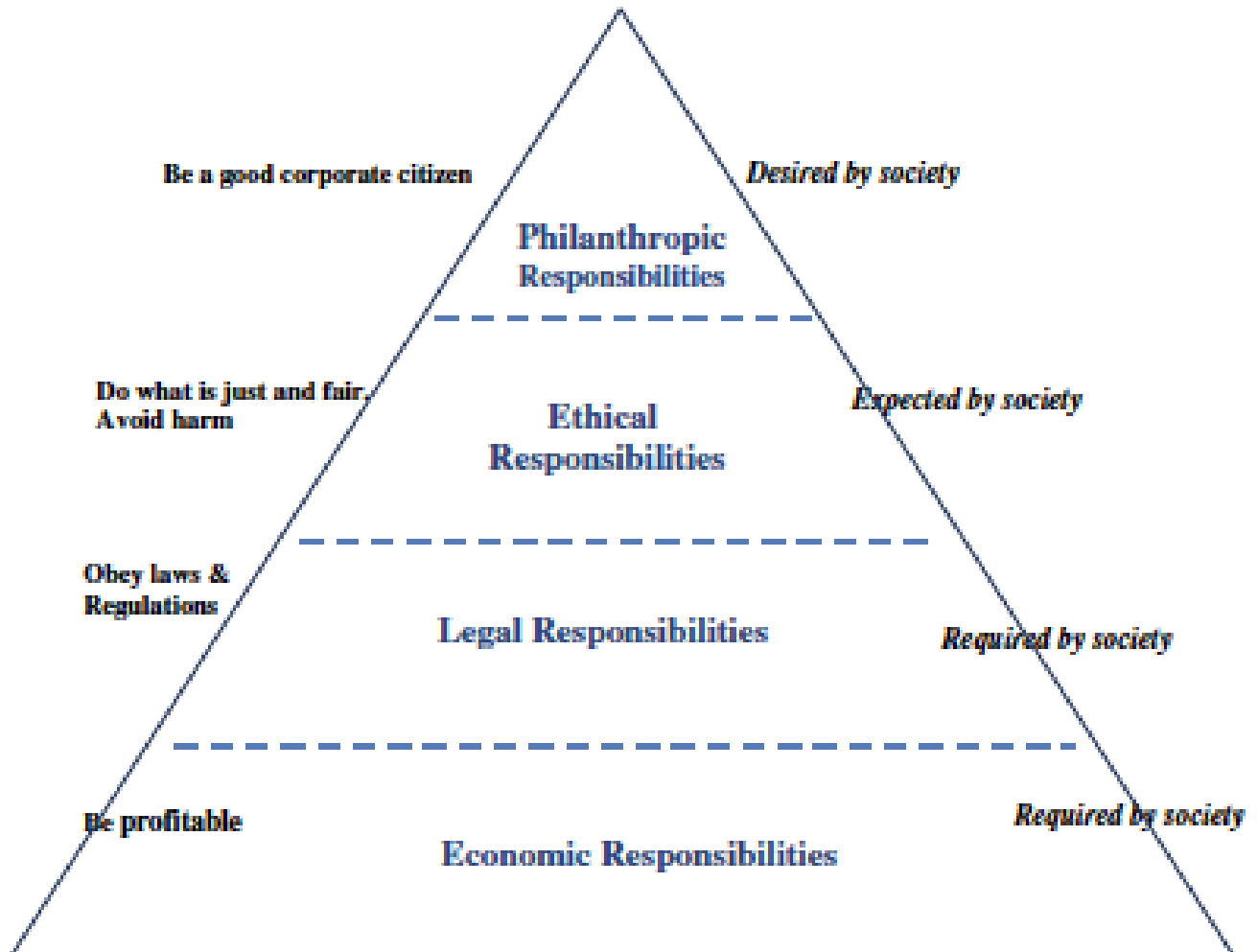
7. Declaration

I affirm that the attached work is entirely my own, except where the words or ideas of other writers are specifically acknowledged according to accepted citation conventions. This assignment has not been submitted for any other course at Robert Kennedy College or any other institution. I have revised, edited and proofread this paper.

I certify that I am the author of this paper and that any assistance I received in its preparation is fully acknowledged and fully disclosed in this paper (examination). I have also cited any sources (footnotes or endnotes) from which I used data, ideas, theories, or words, whether quoted directly or paraphrased. I further acknowledge that this paper has been prepared by myself specifically for this course.

I have read the Student Handbook including the University policy on 'Cheating and Plagiarism' and understand the regulations. I have read the Referencing using the Harvard Method section of the handbook and applied the appropriate referencing system in my assessment.

Appendix 1: Carroll's Pyramid of CSR (Carroll, A.B. 2016)



Appendix 2: Boolean Search String

Boolean Search String	EBSCO/ Discover	Emerald	Science Direct	JSTOR	Oatd	Wiley	Springer	Google Scholar
(csr OR “corporate social responsibility”)	112,166	47,000	34,674	4,647	566,455	24,643	116,714	1,440,000
(csr OR “corporate social responsibility” OR “social responsibility” OR “triple bottom line”)	175,763	11,000	51,493	14,914	692,723	40,100	26,070	1,580,000
(csr OR “corporate social responsibility”) AND (npo OR ngo OR “nonprofit” OR “not for profit” OR nongovernmental OR charity OR “charitable organization”)	9,611	24,000	4,933	1,494	411,046	5,312	57,317	96,300
(csr OR “corporate social responsibility” OR “social responsibility” OR “triple bottom line”) AND (npo OR ngo OR “nonprofit” OR “not for profit” OR nongovernmental OR charity OR “charitable organization”)	13,277	7,000	Too long	3,994	520,830	8,891	16,387	119,000
(csr OR “corporate social responsibility”) AND (csr OR “corporate social irresponsibility” OR “lack of standards” OR “multiple validators”)	253	22	297	20	565,740	225	94	7,100
(csr OR “corporate social responsibility”) AND (csr OR “corporate social irresponsibility” OR “lack of standards” OR “multiple validators”) AND (npo OR ngo OR “nonprofit” OR “not for profit” OR nongovernmental OR charity OR “charitable organization”)	8	0	Too long	Too long	410,970	96	53	83
(csr OR “corporate social responsibility”) AND (npo OR ngo OR “nonprofit” OR “not for profit” OR nongovernmental OR charity OR “charitable organization”) AND (partnership OR partner)	1,392	13,000	Too long	870	9,008	3,426	32,910	52,800
(csr OR “corporate social responsibility”) AND (csr OR “corporate social irresponsibility” OR “lack of standards” OR “multiple validators”) AND (npo OR ngo OR “nonprofit” OR “not for profit” OR nongovernmental OR charity OR “charitable organization”) AND (partnership OR partner)	0	0	Too long	Too long	9,008	72	41	83
(csr OR “corporate social responsibility”) AND (npo OR ngo OR “nonprofit” OR “not for profit” OR nongovernmental OR charity OR “charitable organization”) AND (partnership OR partner) AND (csv OR ivo OR “creating shared value” OR “integrated value creation” OR “collaborative value creation” OR “maturity framework” OR “value creation” OR “mutual value” OR “collaborative value” OR “shared value” OR “mutual benefit”)	33	6,000	Too long	Too long	3,555	617	16,183	8,680
(csr OR “corporate social responsibility”) AND (npo OR ngo OR “nonprofit” OR “not for profit” OR nongovernmental OR charity OR “charitable organization”) AND (partnership OR partner) AND (csv OR ivo OR “creating shared value” OR “integrated value creation” OR “collaborative value creation” OR “maturity framework” OR “value creation” OR “mutual value” OR “collaborative value” OR “shared value” OR “mutual benefit”) AND (“global south” OR “developing countries” OR “developing world” OR “third world”)	2	5,000	Too long	Too long	1,436	270	12,238	8,680

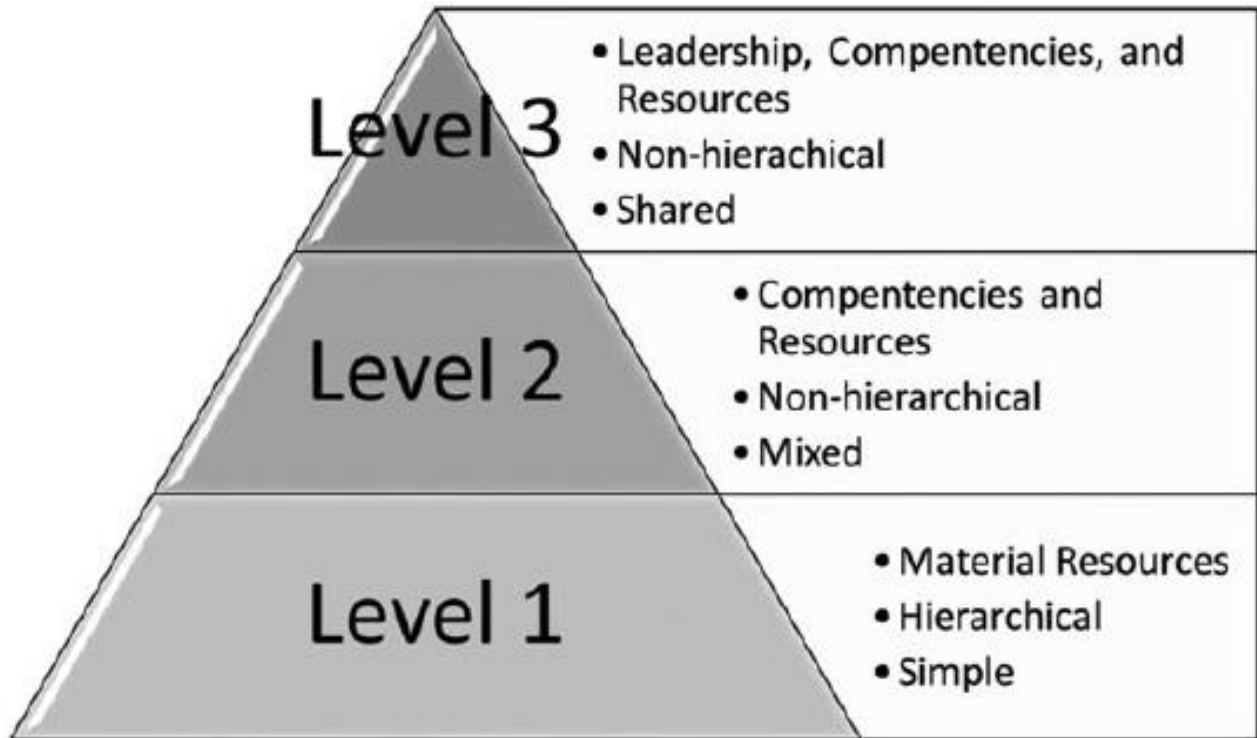
Appendix 3: Key Benefits of a CSR strategy (Industry Canada 2014)

Competitive Advantage	The integration of CSR initiatives across a company can lead to the development of innovative processes, technologies, products or services; addressing sustainability issues through these channels can: • differentiate a company from its competitors; and • enhance a company's reputation and brand.
New business opportunities	Markets for environmentally sustainable and ethical products are expanding, leading to new market opportunities; applying CSR initiatives will help your company to compete on either the supply or demand side of any new opportunity, and to ensure that your existing markets remain viable for the long term.
Access to finance	Financial institutions and institutional investors are increasingly incorporating social and environmental criteria into their assessment of investments and lending. Companies that can demonstrate a strong CSR performance may have preferential access to investment funds or to financing, or may receive preferential terms.
Improve efficiency	Carrying out CSR initiatives related to, for example, energy, water, transportation, packaging, manufacturing processes and waste can often reveal opportunities for efficiencies and cost reductions.
Enhance ability to recruit, develop and retain staff	Employees want to work for companies that reflect their values on the environment and society. Companies that implement a CSR strategy can realize improvements to staff recruitment, engagement and retention.
Improve stakeholder and community relations	CSR initiatives can support companies in building strong relationships with governments, key stakeholders and communities. These relationships can help a company to build and to maintain a "social license to operate" and can evolve into public, private and civil society alliances.
Manage risks	Use CSR initiatives to better anticipate and manage risks related to: Access to resources • Implementing sustainable practices can ensure that a company can continue to access the inputs, e.g., raw materials, it needs to operate into the long term. Operations • Risks such as those arising from extreme weather, community disputes, and health and safety incidents at the premises of your suppliers. Financial and legal exposure • Addressing environmental or community issues before they occur can reduce the probability of having to make more costly investments or to pay for litigation processes after an issue has been exposed. Reputation • CSR initiatives that build trust and credibility can support a company's reputation for delivering products or services while maintaining a strong environmental or social performance. • This is particularly important for organizations with high-value brands that can easily become the focus of media, activist or consumer pressures.

Appendix 4: The evolution of value creation (Visser 2018)

Value type	Focus	Chief exponent
Shareholder value	Financial return to shareholders; “the social responsibility of business is to increase its profits”	Friedman (1970)
Stakeholder value	Distribution of benefits to interested and affected parties; groups with a stake in the business	Freeman (1984)
Four capitals	Extending capital include financial, manufactured, human and natural capital	Ekins (1992)
Triple bottom line	Balanced social, environmental and economic performance; people, planet, profit	Elkington (1994)
Blended value	Simultaneously maximizing social and financial returns; impact investing	Emerson (2000)
Bottom of the pyramid	Serving inclusive markets at the bottom of the economic pyramid, i.e. low-income markets	Prahalad and Hart (2002)
Sustainable value	Combining product stewardship, pollution prevention, clean technology and inclusive strategies	Hart and Milstein (2003)
Five capitals	Extends Ekins’ four capitals model to include a fifth, social capital	Porritt (2007)
Shared value	Finding business opportunities in social problems, through products, value chains and industry clusters	Porter and Kramer (2011)
Integrated value	Innovation synergies through solutions that are secure, smart, shared, sustainable and satisfying	Visser (2017a)

Appendix 5: Three levels of Collaboration (Colaner, Imanaka and Prussia 2018)



Appendix 6: Research Methods utilised in previous similar studies

Researchers have used a variety of methods or combination of methods to perform similar studies and examples of these are illustrated in the following table:

Source	Main Research Objective	Research Methods Used		
		Quantitate Survey/ Questionnaire	Semi- structured interviews	Mixed Method
(Coombes 2017)	To advance current understanding of open business models in a cross-industry and cross-sectoral (public-private) context.		X	
(Knight 2015)	To study value creation in order to construct an understanding of how the organisations working together can lead to societal betterment		X	
(Remund and McKeever 2018)	To examine how corporate and nonprofit leaders partner on public relations for corporate social responsibility (CSR) programs		X	
(Jurgita Mikolaitytė and Vita Juknevičienė 2018)	To identify main contextual (macro and meso) factors influencing cross-sector partnerships creating the collaborative value		X	
(Enciso-Santocildes, Vidu and Gómez-Urquijo 2020)	To show the positive effects of a cross-sector collaboration between public administration and third sector in the Basque Country.		X	
(Matthew Murphy, Daniel Arenas and Joan Manuel Batista 2015)	To analyse types of benefits sought by partners in cross-sector collaborations (between businesses and NPOs)	X		
(Xinya Yan, Haiying Lin and Amelia Clarke 2018)	To explore NGO partners' different roles in a large cross-sector social partnership (CSSP)		X	